OpenClaw Full Stack

The exact toolchain behind a working personal agent

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September 2026 · snapshot of a live Apple-silicon setup

What this is

A snapshot of the software my agent actually runs on, taken from the live machine in September 2026. Use it as a shopping list, not a script: install the core, then add pieces only when a real task needs them.

> Install the minimum. Add a tool the second time you need it, not the first time you imagine it.

1. The core (install these first)

PIECE	WHY
OpenClaw 2026.9.x	The agent gateway: channels, sessions, tools, automations, memory
Node.js 26	OpenClaw's runtime (24.16+ also works)
Claude Code	The Claude login OpenClaw reuses, and a coding agent in its own right
Tailscale	Private network between your machines; nothing exposed to the internet
git + gh	Version your workspace; GitHub from the command line

```
curl -fsSL https://openclaw.ai/install.sh | bash
openclaw gateway install
brew install gh jq tailscale
```

2. Models

ROLE	WHAT WE RUN
Main reasoning	Claude (Sonnet 5 daily, Opus 5.5 for hard problems) through a Claude subscription login
Fallbacks	A second Claude model, configured so an outage doesn't stop the agent
Local bulk work	**Ollama** with Qwen 3.5 35B: summarising and extracting from meeting recordings
Transcription	**mlx-whisper** with `large-v3-turbo` on Apple silicon: voice notes and recordings
Memory search	Small local embedding models (nomic-embed-text, EmbeddingGemma)

```
brew install ollama
ollama pull qwen3.5:35b          # ~23 GB; needs a high-RAM Mac
pip install mlx-whisper          # Apple silicon only
```

Local models are free per call and keep private data on the machine. Only pull the ones you'll actually use: we once found about 150 GB of models nothing had touched in weeks.

3. Command-line tools (Homebrew)

```
brew install ffmpeg        # video and audio processing
brew install yt-dlp        # video downloading
brew install pandoc        # document conversion (Markdown → HTML/PDF/DOCX)
brew install uv            # fast Python environments
brew install himalaya      # email over IMAP/SMTP
brew install ollama        # local models
```

Plus **gog** (Google Workspace: Gmail, Calendar, Drive, Sheets, Docs), which the bundled `gog` skill sets up.

4. Node global packages

What's installed globally on our main machine, grouped by job:

PACKAGE	JOB
`openclaw`	The gateway
`@anthropic-ai/claude-code`	Claude Code CLI
`@openai/codex`, `@google/gemini-cli`	Second-opinion coding agents
`mcporter`	Manage MCP servers from the command line
`agent-browser`	Headless browser automation
`firecrawl-cli`	Scraping and crawling public sites
`vercel`, `@railway/cli`	Deploying sites and services
`docx`, `pptxgenjs`, `sharp`	Generating documents, slides and images

5. Python

Keep one virtual environment for the agent's scripts and always call its Python, never the system one.

```
uv venv ~/.openclaw/workspace/.venv
uv pip install anthropic google-api-python-client google-auth-oauthlib \
  requests beautifulsoup4 pillow pypdf python-pptx playwright
```

6. Memory

LAYER	TOOL
Built-in	OpenClaw's Markdown memory: `USER.md`, `MEMORY.md`, daily notes, memory search
Knowledge graph	**GBrain** (open source): thousands of linked pages about people, projects and decisions, on Postgres + pgvector
Verbatim recall	A searchable index of past conversations, for exact quotes and dates

If you run GBrain alongside many agent sessions, raise Postgres `max_connections`: every session opens its own connection pool.

7. Skills

OpenClaw now ships with hundreds of bundled skills (`openclaw skills list`; about 290 are ready on our machine). The ones that earn their keep for us:

SKILL	JOB
`gog`	Gmail, Calendar, Drive, Sheets, Docs
`himalaya`	Any IMAP/SMTP mailbox
`github`, `gh-issues`	Repos, issues, pull requests
`1password`	Secrets from 1Password
`apple-notes`, `apple-reminders`	Apple's notes and reminders
`firecrawl-*`	Web scraping and search
`browser-automation`	Multi-step browser work
`healthcheck`	Security and hardening audit of the host
`deep-research`	Multi-source research with citations

Install community skills with `openclaw skills install @owner/<slug>` from ClawHub. Our own public skills: ares-skills.

8. Background services

SERVICE	JOB
OpenClaw gateway	Always-on agent (installed by `openclaw gateway install`)
Liveness guard	Every 2 minutes: is the config valid, is the gateway answering?
Health report	Every 6 hours: full check, alerts only on failure
Build health	Daily: every shipped build runs its own health command
Job verifier	Every 15 minutes: did scheduled jobs actually produce their outputs?
Session cleanup	Daily: prunes orphaned sessions and archives old transcripts

Every alert goes through a gate that suppresses repeats unless something gets worse.

9. The fleet

MACHINE	ROLE
Mac mini (main)	The brain: main agent, memory, automations, local models, fleet admin
Mac mini (business)	A separate agent and WhatsApp number for our esports org
iMac	A separate agent for a family business
MacBook Pro	Compute and coding
Cloud server	Backend for a customer-facing product
Windows PC	Gaming and streaming; the agent can drive it for game work

Everything connects over Tailscale and SSH from the main Mac mini.

10. Fresh install, in order

1. Install OpenClaw and finish onboarding (Quick start reuses your Claude login).
2. `openclaw gateway install`, then message the agent from your phone and get a reply.
3. Write `SOUL.md`, `USER.md` and the first rules in `AGENTS.md`. **This is the most important step.**
4. Set `tools.exec.mode` to `ask` and run `openclaw security audit`.
5. Connect one channel: your own WhatsApp or Telegram chat.
6. Add Google (gog) read-only: calendar first, then email.
7. Turn on a morning brief automation.
8. Put the workspace under git and take a backup (`openclaw backup create`).
9. Only now add local models, more channels, more skills and more machines, one at a time.

Companion to The OpenClaw Bible. Updates at github.com/rushindrasinha/openclaw-guide.